CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

AUTO DETAILING (MOBILE/OWNER) IN THE AI ERA

A robot vacuum can clean a rug. Nobody hands a machine an expensive car and a clay bar.

★ TL;DR — Owner detailers sit around ~$75K on the site's scale, startable in 1–6 months with no license. The catch: it's premium-priced manual labor — your hands set the ceiling until you add help. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

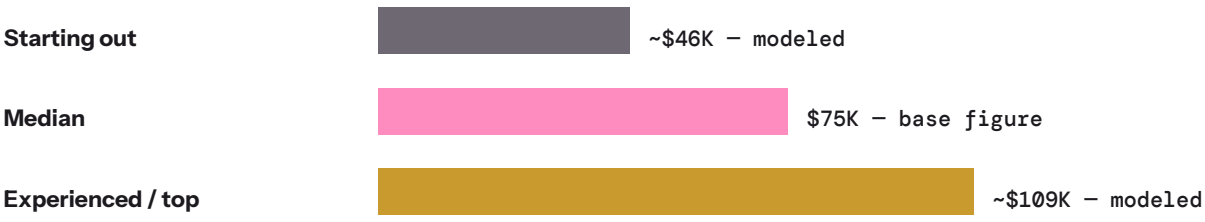
OUR TAKE: YES — WITH EYES OPEN

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW

- Mobile detailing is a classic low-cost, high-margin owner business.
- Ceramic coatings and paint correction are where the ticket sizes jump.
- Booking and marketing are software now; the finish is judged by human eyes.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Auto Detailing (mobile/owner) is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A AUTO DETAILING (MOBILE/OWNER) ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Wash, clay, polish and protect paint inside and out
- ✓ Deep-clean interiors: extraction, steam and leather care
- ✓ Apply waxes and ceramic coatings
- ✓ Quote, schedule and photograph finished cars for marketing

Think: a barber for cars — craft, chemicals and before/after photos.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Booking apps, CRM reminders and AI-assisted marketing run the business side. Quoting tools estimate jobs from customer photos.	Reading paint condition, correcting swirls without burning clear coat, and the final inspection under light — the quality call is human.

⚠ **Cheap detailers are everywhere; racing them on price destroys your back and your margins at the same time.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Satisfying transformations with same-day results ✓ Mobile setup means low overhead and clients' driveways ✓ Enthusiast clients tip and refer generously	✗ Chemicals, heat and bent-over hours are the daily texture ✗ Weekend demand peaks when clients are off work ✗ Weather calls the schedule for mobile work

Good fit? Detail-obsessed, patient, and happy working with your hands all day.
Bad fit? You want fast, sloppy volume, or can't stand chemical smells.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — DETAIL FOR A SHOP FIRST	DOOR B — MOBILE FROM DAY ONE
Work at a detail shop or dealership prep department for a season: learn compounds, pads, coatings and production pace on other people's cars before betting your own money.	Buy a starter kit, practice on family cars, and launch mobile packages in your neighborhood. Low overhead, and every job becomes portfolio content if you photograph it.

Smart move: Sell maintenance plans and ceramic packages, not one-off washes — recurring revenue and big tickets live there.

Where you land after: Booked-out solo detailer → a helper → a small shop with a coating bay.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
LEARN THE	BUILD THE	SET UP	PRICE FOR	FILL THE	ADD RECURRING

STEP 1 — Learn the process

FREE · WEEKS

- Study the sequence: wash, decontaminate, correct, protect.
- Practice full details on your own and family cars, timed.

STEP 2 — Build the kit

STARTER BUDGET · MONTHS 1-2

- Polisher, pads, compounds, extractor, steamer and safe chemicals.
- Buy for the packages you'll sell, not for internet wish lists.

STEP 3 — Set up the business

WEEKS

- Register, insure, and build a booking page with clear packages.
- Photograph everything: before/after is your entire ad strategy.

STEP 4 — Price for profit

MONTHS 2-3

- Charge by condition and time; never flat-guess a trashed interior.
- Create a premium tier: correction plus ceramic coating.

STEP 5 — Fill the calendar

ONGOING

- Dealerships, fleets and realtors are steady B2B sources.
- Ask every happy client for photos, a review and one referral.

STEP 6 — Add recurring revenue

MONTH 6

- Monthly maintenance plans for your best clients.
- When booked out two weeks, raise prices before hiring.

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

□ Today: detail your own car start to finish and time every stage.

□ Days 1–30: kit assembled, practice details done, packages written.

□ Days 31–60: business live, first paying cars, photo portfolio growing.

 Days 61–90: premium package launched; B2B pitches to dealers and realtors.

 Day 90: a working mobile detail business with reviews and a repeat list.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **THE FINISH IS THE AD.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.